

7 Questions to Ensure your AI Success

This article discusses six broad stages of artificial intelligence (AI) solution lifecycle.

New age AI solutions can be highly potent and may result in scalable damage when something goes wrong.



Acmé Solutions (a hypothetical company) is experiencing significant growth in its products and services. Acme's customer base is continuously increasing. An increase in the customer base is leading to an increased number of calls to their incident management support centre.

To keep up with the growth, Acme Solutions does not want to increase the headcount in their incident management support centre by implementing an artificial intelligent (AI) chatbot solution. By doing this, they expect to provide adequate support to incidents reported by customers, without additional headcount. Customers will be able to interact with chatbot and report their problems to, perhaps, get instant solutions too.

Should Acme Solutions embark on an AI chatbot project? If this project is completed, will it solve Acme's problem(s)?

If you think deeply, you will realise a flaw in Acme's thought process—their hypothesis. Their hypothesis is, if we implement an AI chatbot, we can address the increased number of customer reported incidents without the increased headcount.

What is wrong here?

The very first problem here is 'retrofit thinking.' Acme Solutions is starting with a solution in mind and then trying to fit in with their current issue of growing customer base and incident reports. They formed their hypothesis while already choosing the solution, which is the fundamental mistake in hypothesis framing.

Instead, if they focus on the problem first, the solution may be different. If Acme acknowledges that an increase in customer base is leading to increased incident reports, there is a fundamental flaw in their service or product. There is something inherent in their service or

product that is causing incidents in the first place, and the best way to address it is to eliminate the cause of incidents.

Once Acme realises that solving flaws in product/service would eliminate or reduce the number of reported incidents, their need for increased headcount is likely to go away. When that happens, the need for AI chatbot will go away too.

In this case, if Acme were to go ahead with an AI chatbot, their incident count will not reduce. However, they will be able to respond to more customers that are reporting incidents. Now, no matter how intelligent and efficient this chatbot is, once customers start to report an incident, it means that they are already unhappy and frustrated with Acme's product and service. Acme's brand loyalty has already taken a hit. Solving customer problems would not restore it; at best, it will stop it from getting worse.